To get a feel for the physics, imagine you are an art collector and Mr. Smithers, chairman of the new Springfield Art and Beautification Society, is coming to look at various works you have put up for sale. You know, however, that his real interest is in *The Full Monty,* a painting in your collection that you never felt quite fit, but one that was left to you by your beloved great-uncle Monty Burns, so that deciding whether to sell it is quite an emotional struggle. After Mr. Smithers arrives, you talk about your collection, recent auctions, the current show at the Metropolitan; surprisingly, you learn that, years back, Smithers was your great-uncle's top aide. By the end of the conversation you decide that you are willing to part with *The Full Monty:* There are so many other works you want, and you must exercise restraint or your collection will have no focus. In the world of art collecting, you have always told yourself, sometimes more is less.

As you reflect back upon this decision, in retrospect it seems that you had actually already decided to sell before Mr. Smithers arrived. Although you have always had a certain affection for *The Full Monty,* you have long been wary of amassing a sprawling collection and late-twentieth-century erotic-nuclear realism is an intimidating area for all but the most seasoned collector. Even though you remember that before your visitor's arrival you had been thinking that you didn't know what to do, from your current vantage point it seems as though you really did. It is not quite that future events have affected the past, but your enjoyable meeting with Mr. Smithers and your subsequent declaration of your willingness to sell have illuminated the past in a way that makes definite particular things that seemed undecided at the time. It is as though the meeting and your declaration helped you to accept a decision that was already made, one that was waiting to be ushered forth into the light of day. The future has helped you tell a more complete story of what was going on in the past.

Of course, in this example, future events are affecting only your perception or interpretation of the past, so the events are neither puzzling nor surprising. But the delayed-choice experiment of Wheeler transports this psychological interplay between the future and the past into the quantum realm, where it becomes both precise and startling. We begin with the experiment in Figure 7.1a, modified by turning the laser down so it fires one photon at a time, as in Figure 7.1b, and also by attaching a